

Influencer Publics and the Divergent Construction of Social Media Realities

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ABSTRACT

Social media influencers are increasingly supplanting "traditional" news media as trusted sources of information about highly-politicized topics. My dissertation proposes a new unit of analysis to understand these influencers: the *influencer public*. The influencer public is a space of discourse where hypervisible social media influencers not only frame but create the topics of relevant political discussion through their interactions with each other and their audiences. These influencers work every day with and against their audiences to cultivate attention, which they can then transform into monetary rewards, political power, or simply libidinal enjoyment. The work I share here documents ways which we may represent these influencer publics to ourselves using mixed-methods network analyses, and documents how these influencer publics can create highly divergent informational "realities" for their audiences. This work on influencers stems from CSCW's focus on the sociotechnical structure of online influence operations, and hopes to extend this literature from an analysis of individual campaigns to an analysis of ongoing environments and meaning-making processes.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Applied computing → Sociology; • Human-centered computing → Social network analysis; • Social and professional topics → Political speech.

KEYWORDS

influencers, social media, publics, evidence, audiences

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1 INTRODUCTION

A growing share of people in the United States get their news from social media, and that news is increasingly mediated outside of mainstream journalistic institutions [13, 15]. Particularly, political influencers have come to dominate social media publics [9],

exploiting attention economies first established in commercial influencer communities [1]. These influencers form a certain warped and bounded public sphere on the platforms they occupy, framing not only exogenous news and issues, but also endogenous controversy spawned from their interactions with each other and their audiences [11]. These influencers have been implicated in mass disinformation campaigns relating to election denial [7], vaccine refusal [6], and rising racist [8], misogynist [2], and anti-queer [12] hate movements in the United States.

Influencers rarely act alone; indeed part of the excitement of following influencers is watching how they interact with other influencers, positively and negatively, in a highly-visible online community [10]. Rising social media platforms have been characterized by the absence of formal community boundaries, as were once provided by the subreddits of Reddit, the groups of Facebook, or the message boards of interest-based websites. Instead, platforms like Twitter, TikTok, and Instagram are defined by their *lack of structure*, where users are invited to explore an indefinite network containing many unknown communities. The ability to traverse this network is mediated by social relationships, but also by ever-changing algorithms which expose or conceal potential community members to users. These technologies have exacerbated a persistent question in sociology, communication, and political science: how can we represent communities, and particularly the publics in which we process political priorities, in discourse spaces with informal, constantly-renegotiated boundaries?

I propose in my thesis work to provide a toolkit for understanding what I call *influencer publics*: a type of public sphere whose discourse and subject matter is mediated through the hypervisible actions of a set of social media influencers who include both traditional actors (politicians, news outlets, journalists) and a growing set of internet-first influencers. My completed and proposed work explores how the way we understand these publics is contingent on how one defines social interaction, whether it be fleeting or frequent, positive or negative, passive or active. My proposed longitudinal studies evaluate how these publics respond to exogenous interventions, such as platform moderation, as well as how they naturally transform over years in response to audience and influencer preferences. Finally, I have studied how different influencer publics discussing the same topics use coordinated citation produce highly divergent constructions of reality among their audiences.

The question of representing and analyzing influencer publics is a primary concern for scholars of computer supported collaborative work. Previous work has described how strategic influence operations are a primary concern for the field of CSCW, given its interplay between formal, goal-driven organizations and the constraints and affordances of the technological platforms upon which they must

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strive [14]. I see the analysis of influencer publics as drawing connections between the CSCW literature on influence operations into closely related fields of political communication and sociology. Influencers are goal-driven, seeking to exploit the attention economy for monetary gain, political power, election victories, or simply personal enjoyment. Influencers work constantly, in collaboration and sometimes in opposition to their audiences, to achieve their goals, using the unique affordances of different social media platforms to cultivate and exploit attention. The widely-recognized success they have achieved in their efforts has influenced the design of new social media platforms, modifications to existing platforms, and behavior changes in platform users. Characterizing and understanding the effects of these communities of influencers is critical for designing these systems, now and in the future.

2 COMPLETED AND SUBMITTED WORK

My completed and submitted work includes my initial study of influencer communities during the 2020 United States presidential election [4], my study of politicized interactions with the "alternative media ecosystem" on Facebook [5], and my submitted study on the construction of different scientific consensus on mask-wearing during the COVID-19 pandemic [3]. My first paper serves to illustrate the essential difficulty and risk of defining influencer publics using social media data; depending on the methods and social interaction datasets chosen, the apparent emergent communities in a given discourse will appear to change. This paper also contains an extensive empirical analysis of the nature of these influencer publics, the overlaps between different publics, and the fate of these publics in the wake of platform moderation after the 2020 election [4] (Figure 1).

This empirical analysis segues into my analysis of political demographics in the alternative media ecosystem — an influencer public unto itself. The alternative media ecosystem, also surfaced in my work on the 2020 election, selectively appeals to far-right and far-left leaning users depending on the political issue being debated. I show this selectivity using a large, anonymized dataset of Facebook user interactions classified by users' apparent political affiliation. These results show the agility and flexibility of influencer publics in the attention economy, exploiting legacies of alternately anti-imperialist and libertarian thought to maximize attention via radically different audiences [5].

I conclude by documenting how influencer publics translate attention into real-world effects via what I and my colleagues call the social construction of scientific consensus. Using a large dataset of Twitter users arguing with each other about the efficacy of masks for preventing COVID-19, I analyze the sources they bring to bear in their arguments, and show how those in favor of masks tend to cite a mainstream roster of doctors, hospitals, government sources, and popular media, while those against masks cite a roster of conspiracy theorists, alternative media journalists, and wellness influencers. Both rosters extensively and convincingly cite their sources, but their sources are entirely different, leading their audiences into separate informational worlds and constructed realities. This study exposes the link between influencers and "offline" effects: the influencers one trusts mediates the information one has access to, and consequently the reality one must form decisions from [3].

3 IN-PROGRESS AND PROPOSED WORK

The remainder of my thesis will be driven by two primary questions: how do influencer publics and their audiences change over time, and how do *negative* affective interactions change the way we understand who is, and is not, part of a public?

3.0.1 Longitudinal Analyses. I am currently working on two studies analyzing longitudinal transformations of influencer publics, both centered on a dataset cultivated from work performed in my first article on the 2020 election [4]. Specifically, I have identified a cohort of 3,000 US-focused Twitter influencers whose posts were highly shared during the 2020 election, and continuously collected information about what these influencers post, and which users shared their content, until March 2023. The resulting dataset contains data on over 2B+ tweets made by these publics in the last two years.

My first question uses the convenience of the new 2022 election to ask: how have right- and left-leaning issue publics changed since the 2020 United States election? My approach is primarily methodological, in that I attempt to define the multiple ways in which *change* can be conceptualized and operationalized, and evaluate these measures across two time periods with similar events. My preliminary results show that different measures of change can be conflictual: publics may seem to grow in size, in terms of the number of members participating in a conversation, but decrease in activity, in terms of the number of users postings and sharing content related to a given discourse. I interpret what these conflictual meanings of change mean in light of popular debates about how left- and particularly right-leaning publics should be intervened upon during and after United States elections.

My second question focuses less on the influencers themselves, and more on their audiences. Specifically, I seek to characterize the trajectories that users who share influencers' content take over time, once they first become engaged with these publics. To do this, I create month-by-month influencer "diets" for all users who persistently share influencers' content in our data, and using clustering techniques show how users' tend to change their diets over time and in response to specific events in our dataset. Preliminary findings show a diet of mainstream media outlets is an entry point to influencer publics, where users gradually move from these outlets to more internet-native influencers over time.

3.1 Negative Affect and Influencers

My final study stems from a qualitative coding project I have been leading with undergraduate, Masters, and PhD students at the University of Washington. Our team has been coding positive and hostile interactions between influencers of different publics via quote tweets, where one influencer exposes the content of another influencer to their audience. Our goal is to use this coded data to fine-tune an existing language model and detect hostile interactions across the much larger longitudinal dataset from the previous section.

Our simple empirical question is: which influencers receive the highest proportions of negative-to-positive exposure, and why? Our more complex question is how the addition of information about negative affect changes the observed structure of influencer publics. Are their certain communities of influencers who are distinguished

Influencer Publics in the 2020 United States Presidential Election

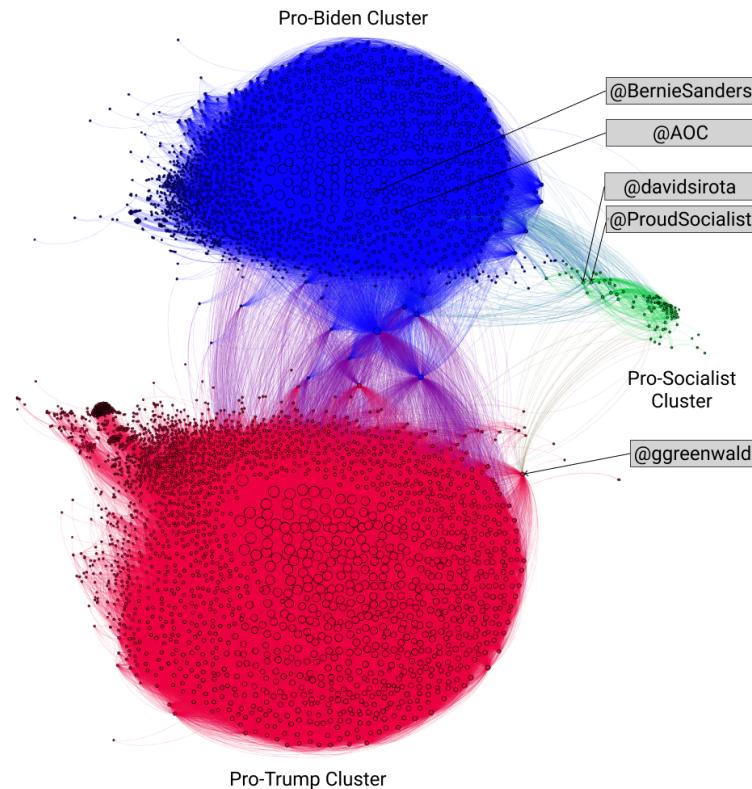


Figure 1: A network visualization modified from [4] of different influencer publics on Twitter during the 2020 United States presidential election. Each node represents one influencer, and influencers are connected if they were both retweeted at least five times by at least 100 other users. Nodes are colored according to the results of a clustering algorithm. Labeled nodes are influencers who straddle the boundaries between publics, selectively appealing to different audiences from post to post.

because they receive consistent hatred from other communities? Are their other communities which are consistently ignored, and receive relatively little negative affect? A motivation that undergirds these questions is to understand how those influencers we dislike may still be considered part of our publics as anti-examples, and how these anti-examples affect the framing and construction of disparate social realities.

4 BIOGRAPHICAL SKETCH

I am a PhD candidate at the University of Washington's Department of Human Centered Design and Engineering (HCDE). I am advised by Kate Starbird (HCDE) and Emma S. Spiro, from the University of Washington's iSchool, and am a member of UW's Center for an Informed Public. My work uses a combination of methods derived from network science, such as network visualization, clustering, and statistical analysis, and qualitative content analysis, including qualitative coding. The primary motivation in my work is to create resources and frameworks that activists, academics, and the public can use to discuss and address "problematic information" on the internet. My hope in attending the CSCW DC is to spark

discussions with my peers about how researchers can effectively research highly politicized topics using the sociotechnical frames that are typical in the CSCW community. How do we represent, to ourselves, the political realities of the moment, and how do those representation converge or diverge with the realities that social media idols construct for internet-users every day?

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